The Simple-Prompt Myth: Useful Detail Beats Brevity

Kabui, Charles

2026-07-26

Read at ToKnow.ai



Short prompts are not automatically better. In a May 2026 study, researchers compared raw, checklist, and clarification-first prompts across eight tasks and three chatbots, producing 72 scored outputs. Checklist prompts named the rules, context, and answer format. They averaged 7.50 out of 8, against 5.67 for raw prompts, and cut mean total tokens from 962 to 683. Coding showed the biggest gap: 7.83 versus 4.67. That is useful evidence, but not a

universal law. The operators also judged the outputs, the task set was tiny, and the paper did not isolate which checklist item caused the gain.

A larger January 2026 coding study started with 1,682 Python tasks from three benchmarks and four models. Researchers focused on prompts that failed repeatedly, used test feedback to repair them, then manually studied 627 successful prompt rewrites. Algorithm details appeared in 57%, explicit input and output formats in 44%, examples in 24%, and postconditions in 23%. The method finds common ingredients, not their individual causal effect, and its authors say they did not measure whether the guidelines improve normal developer work. Still, both studies support the same practical rule: add information that removes a decision the model would otherwise guess. State the goal, relevant context, constraints, expected output, and real edge cases. Stop there. OpenAI's current guidance likewise recommends clear instruction sections, examples, context, and tests. Length is a side effect of useful detail, not the target.

Read More: Does better code need a prompt longer than the code itself?

Sources:

- Less Back-and-Forth: A Comparative Study of Structured Prompting
- Guidelines to Prompt Large Language Models for Code Generation
- OpenAI prompt engineering guide
- GitHub Copilot task-writing best practices

Disclaimer: *For information only. Accuracy or completeness not guaranteed. Illegal use prohibited. Not professional advice or solicitation.* ***Read more:*** */terms-of-service*